

IH06

Delhi Sultanate

2-3 questions a paper. The two proven hotspots are Alauddin Khalji's market regulations (2024, a full statement question plus a source question) and Krishnadevaraya with the Ashtadiggajas (2021, 2023 and 2024 - three papers running). There is also a permanent Rajasthan hook: Aibak built the Adhai Din ka Jhonpra at Ajmer, and Alauddin took Ranthambore in 1301 and Chittor in 1303.

Three hundred and twenty years, five dynasties, one throne. From Aibak in 1206 to Ibrahim Lodi at Panipat in 1526. RPSC asks this chapter through administration and personalities - Alauddin Khalji's market control, Muhammad bin Tughlaq's experiments, Firoz Shah's taxes - plus Vijayanagara, which it has now asked in three consecutive papers.

Delhi Sultanate 1206-1526

Slave / Mamluk 1206-90

- Aibak - Lakh Baksh
- Iltutmish - Iqta, Chalisa, tanka
- Raziya - only woman ruler
- Balban - Zill-i-Ilahi, sijda

Sayyid and Lodi

- Khizr Khan 1414
- Bahlul Lodi 1451 - first Afghan
- Sikandar Lodi - Agra 1504
- Ibrahim Lodi - Panipat 1526

Khalji 1290-1320

- Jalaluddin Firoz - founder
- Alauddin - market control
- Kharaj 50%, masahat
- Gujarat, Ranthambore, Chittor, Malwa
- Malik Kafur in the Deccan

Administration

- Diwan-i-Wizarat, Arz, Insha, Risalat, Qaza
- Iqta - muqti, fawazil
- Tanka and jital

Tughlaq 1320-1414

- Ghiyasuddin - Tughlaqabad
- Muhammad bin Tughlaq - five experiments
- Ibn Battuta - Rihla
- Firoz Shah - canals, jizya, Ashokan pillars

The south

- Vijayanagara 1336 - Harihara and Bukka
- Krishnadevaraya - Amuktamalyada
- Ashtadiggajas
- Talikota 1565
- Bahmani 1347 - Mahmud Gawan

From Tarain to Delhi - how the Sultanate begins

Turkish rule in north India is settled by two battles at the same place. In 1191 Prithviraj Chauhan III beat Muhammad Ghori at Tarain. In 1192 Ghori came back and beat Prithviraj at the same field. Two years later Ghori defeated Jaichandra of Kannauj at Chandawar. After Ghori's death his slave-general Qutbuddin Aibak declared himself sultan at Lahore in 1206, and the Delhi Sultanate begins. Note the pattern the examiner likes: first Tarain the Rajput won, second Tarain the Turk won.

- First Battle of Tarain, 1191 - Prithviraj Chauhan III defeated Muhammad Ghori.
- Second Battle of Tarain, 1192 - Ghori defeated Prithviraj.
- Battle of Chandawar, 1194 - Ghori defeated Jaichandra of Kannauj.
- Delhi Sultanate runs 1206 to 1526.

The five dynasties with dates - learn this as one string



YAAD RAKHO

Five dynasties, one order: Slave, Khalji, Tughlaq, Sayyid, Lodi - S-K-T-S-L.
 And anchor four dates: 1206 start, 1290 Khalji, 1320 Tughlaq, 1526 end.
 Ordering questions on the five dynasties are a standing RAS format.

The Slave or Mamluk dynasty - the state gets built

Mamluk means a slave of Turkish origin who rose to be an officer. Aibak founded the line but ruled only four years and left everything unfinished. The real builder is Iltutmish. He moved the capital from Lahore to Delhi, created the iqta system to pay his soldiers with land revenue instead of cash, formed the Chalisa or corps of forty Turkish nobles to run the state, and issued the two coins the Sultanate then used for three centuries - the silver tanka and the copper jital. He also got formal recognition from the Abbasid Caliph in 1229, which made his rule legitimate in Islamic law.

- Qutbuddin Aibak (1206-1210) - called Lakh Baksh, giver of lakhs, for his charity.
 - Began the Qutb Minar; built the Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque at Delhi and the Adhai Din ka Jhonpra at Ajmer.
 - Died at Lahore falling from his horse while playing chaugan, that is polo.
 - The Ajmer link matters for RAS - Adhai Din ka Jhonpra appears in the Rajasthan architecture chapter too.
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- Iltutmish (1211-1236) - the real consolidator; shifted the capital from Lahore to Delhi.
 - Created the Iqta system and the Turkan-i-Chahalgani, the Chalisa or corps of forty.
 - Issued the silver tanka and the copper jital; completed the Qutb Minar.
 - Received investiture from the Abbasid Caliph in 1229.
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- Raziya (1236-1240) - the only woman ever to rule the Delhi Sultanate.
 - Nominated by Iltutmish over his own sons - a deliberate choice, not an accident.
 - Raised the Abyssinian Jamal-ud-din Yaqut to Amir-i-Akhur, master of the horse.
 - Overthrown by the Turkish nobility, who would not accept a woman ruler.

- Balban (1266-1287) - kingship as Zill-i-Ilahi, the Shadow of God on earth.
- Introduced sijda, prostration before the sultan, and paibos, kissing his feet; revived the Persian Nauroz.
- Destroyed the Chalisa that had made him - the forty were the rival power centre.
- Blood and iron policy; created the Diwan-i-Arz, the military department, and an espionage network of barids.

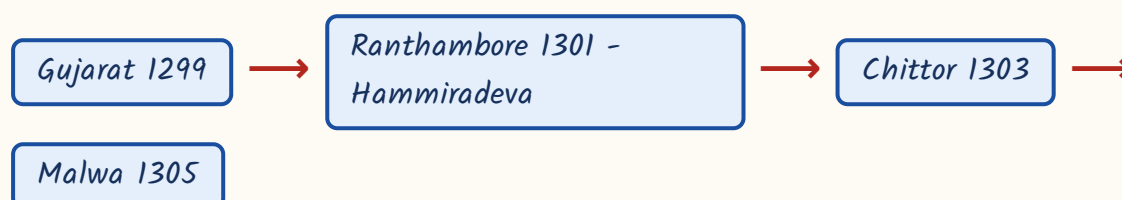
TRAP

Aibak began the Qutb Minar, Iltutmish completed it - do not credit either with the whole. And Balban was not the last Slave ruler; weak successors followed him before the Khaljis took over in 1290.

The Khaljis - Alauddin's conquests

The Khalji dynasty was founded by Jalaluddin Firoz Khalji in 1290. He was old and mild, and his nephew and son-in-law Alauddin was neither. Alauddin raided Devagiri in the Deccan in 1296, came back loaded with treasure, murdered his uncle and seized the throne. That Deccan wealth is what financed everything he then did. Then he swept the north-west and Rajasthan, and sent Malik Kafur south.

Alauddin's conquests in order - a proven ordering question



- Malik Kafur's Deccan campaigns hit Devagiri, Warangal, Dwarasamudra and Madurai.
 - The Deccan kingdoms were made tributaries rather than annexed.
 - Ranthambore and Chittor tie this chapter directly to Rajasthan History - Hammiradeva of Ranthambore and the 1303 siege of Chittor.
 - Alauddin was the first Sultan to attempt a systematic control of prices.
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- Alauddin built the Alai Darwaza in 1311, the Siri fort and the Hauz-i-Alai (Hauz Khas).
 - The Alai Minar, meant to dwarf the Qutb Minar, was left unfinished.
 - Amir Khusrau, called Tuti-i-Hind, the Parrot of India, wrote Khazain-ul-Futuh and Qiran-us-Sadain.
 - Khusrau served several sultans, not Alauddin alone - a common trap option.

Alauddin Khalji's market and revenue reforms - the single most asked topic here

Understand why before you learn what. Alauddin needed a very large standing army to face Mongol raids, and he paid it in cash. A large army paid in fixed cash salaries only works if prices stay fixed too - otherwise the salary buys less each year and the soldiers desert. So the price control was not welfare policy; it was military finance. That reasoning is worth writing down, because RPSC's statement questions on this topic reward understanding the system, not just naming officers.

Alauddin's control system under three heads



- Four markets were regulated - the grain mandi; the Sarai Adl for cloth and manufactures; a market for horses, slaves and cattle; and a general market.
- Prices were fixed by the Sultan and enforced, not negotiated.
- Grain was stockpiled in state granaries so supply could be released when traders held back.
- Merchants were registered and the fixed rates were enforced on pain of punishment.
- Diwan-i-Riyasat - the officer in overall charge of the markets.
- Shahna-i-Mandi - superintendent of the grain market.
- Barids - intelligence officers; munhiyans - secret spies.
- Barids and munhiyans reported on the markets directly to the Sultan, bypassing the officials they watched.
- The fullest account is Ziauddin Barani's Tarikh-i-Firuz Shahi.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2024 set a statement question on exactly this: the Diwan-i-Riyasat was in overall charge, the Shahna-i-Mandi supervised the grain market, and barids and munhiyans reported directly to the Sultan. All three statements were correct. Learn the three names and who they answered to.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2024 also asked where our fullest account of the market regulations comes from. Answer - the Tarikh-i-Firuz Shahi of Ziauddin Barani. Note the trap in the title: Barani's book is named after Firoz Shah Tughlaq but is our main source for Alauddin Khalji.

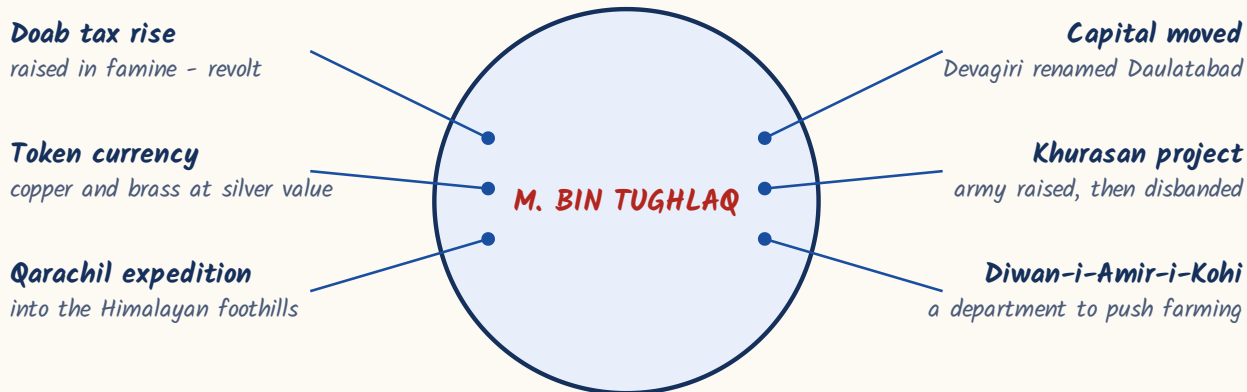
- Revenue side - kharaj raised to 50 per cent of produce, the highest in the Sultanate.
- Assessment by measurement, masahat, on the yield per biswa - not by guess or by sharing.
- Two new taxes added - ghari, a house tax, and charai, a grazing tax.
- The privileges of the khuts, muqaddams and chaudharis, the rural intermediaries, were abolished.
- Diwan-i-Mustakhraj created to recover arrears; milk, inam and waqf grants were resumed by the state.

The Tughlaqs - the reformer who failed and the one who lasted

Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq founded the dynasty in 1320 and built the fortified city of Tughlaqabad. His son Muhammad bin Tughlaq, 1325 to 1351, is the most discussed sultan of the whole period. He was learned, original and disastrous. Every one of his major projects was defensible on paper and failed in practice - which is exactly why examiners like him. Learn the five experiments as a set, and learn one reason for each failure.

Take the two most asked. The capital transfer: Devagiri, renamed Daulatabad, sits in the middle of the empire and was the sensible administrative centre - but he moved the whole population of Delhi, not just the government, and the march killed people; he then reversed it. The token currency: copper and brass coins issued at the value of silver would have worked if the mint had been a state monopoly - but the coins had no distinctive mark, households forged them freely, and the treasury had to redeem the forgeries. It failed on counterfeiting, not on the idea.

The experiments of Muhammad bin Tughlaq, 1325-1351



- Increase of taxation in the Doab - imposed during famine, it provoked revolt.
- Transfer of the capital from Delhi to Devagiri, renamed Daulatabad.
- Token currency in copper and brass at the value of silver - widely counterfeited.
- The Khurasan project - a huge army raised for a foreign expedition, then disbanded.
- The Qarachil expedition into the Himalayan foothills - destroyed by terrain and weather.
- Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi created to promote agriculture - a state department for farming.

- Ibn Battuta, the Moroccan traveller, was made qazi of Delhi by Muhammad bin Tughlaq.
- He was later sent as envoy to China; his account is the Rihla.
- Firoz Shah Tughlaq (1351-1388) dug the largest canal network of the Sultanate.
- He levied four taxes on the Islamic model - kharaj, zakat, jizya, khams - and added the irrigation cess haqq-i-sharb at one-tenth.
- He was the first to impose jizya on Brahmanas, who had been exempt before.
- Founded Firozabad, Hisar, Fatehabad and Jaunpur; set up the Diwan-i-Khairat, a charity department, and the Dar-ul-Shafa, a free hospital.
- Brought Ashokan pillars from Topra and Meerut to Delhi; his memoir is the Futuh-i-Firozshahi.

Alauddin Khalji against Muhammad bin Tughlaq - the standard contrast

Alauddin Khalji	Muhammad bin Tughlaq
Controlled prices to pay a cash army	Issued token currency to stretch the treasury
Kharaj at 50 per cent, measured by masahat	Raised Doab taxes during a famine
Kept Delhi as capital and fortified Siri	Moved the capital to Daulatabad and back
Made the Deccan tributary through Malik Kafur	Tried to hold the Deccan directly and lost it
Ruthless but effective	Original but unworkable

TRAP

Muhammad bin Tughlaq's token currency was copper and brass, not leather and not paper. And it failed because it was easily counterfeited, not because people refused to accept it.

Sayyids, Lodis, and how the Sultanate was run

After Timur sacked Delhi in 1398, during the reign of Nasiruddin Mahmud Tughlaq, the Sultanate never recovered its reach. The Sayyids and Lodis ruled a shrunken kingdom. The Lodis matter for one reason: they were Afghans, not Turks, and Afghan nobles treated the king as first among equals rather than as a master. Ibrahim Lodi tried to reverse that, alienated his nobles, and one of them invited Babur. That is how 1526 happens.

- Timur invaded and sacked Delhi in 1398, under Nasiruddin Mahmud Tughlaq.
- Sayyid dynasty founded by Khizr Khan in 1414, Timur's deputy at Multan; last ruler Alam Shah.
- Lodi dynasty founded by Bahlul Lodi in 1451 - the first Afghan dynasty of Delhi.
- Sikandar Lodi founded Agra in 1504, introduced the Gaz-i-Sikandari measure, wrote Persian verse as Gulrukhi.
- Ibrahim Lodi was defeated and killed by Babur at the First Battle of Panipat, 21 April 1526.

CURRENT LINK

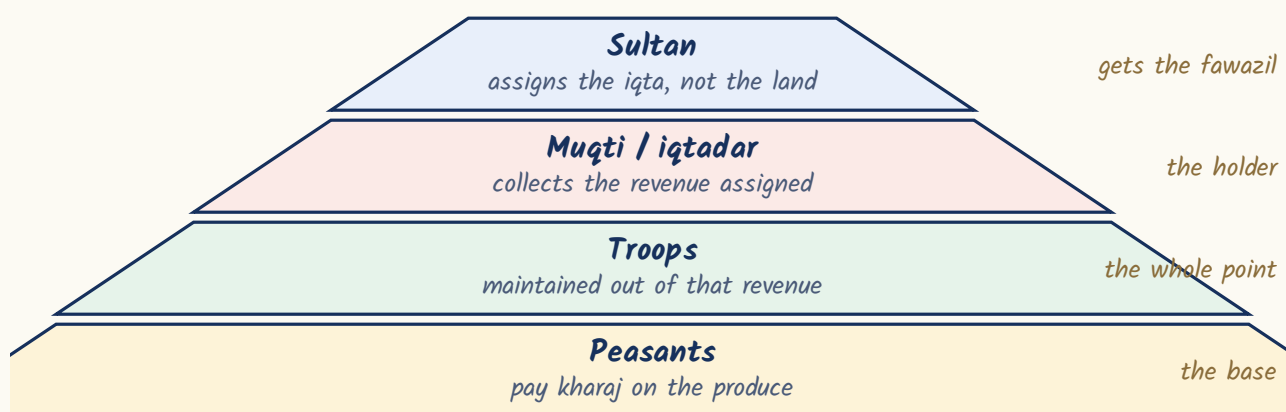
Current link: April 2026 completed five hundred years since the First Battle of Panipat, fought on 21 April 1526, where Babur defeated and killed Ibrahim Lodi and the Delhi Sultanate ended. Position as of September 2026. Round-number anniversaries are a standing source for the current-affairs block, so keep the three Panipats apart - 1526 Babur against Ibrahim Lodi, 1556 Akbar's side against Hemu, 1761 the Marathas against Ahmad Shah Abdali.

The central departments - diwan means department

Department	Charge	Head
Diwan-i-Wizarat	Finance and revenue	Wazir
Diwan-i-Arz	Military	Ariz-i-Mamalik
Diwan-i-Insha	Royal correspondence	Dabir-i-Khas
Diwan-i-Risalat	Religious affairs and appeals	Sadr-us-Sudur
Diwan-i-Qaza	Justice	Qazi-ul-Quzat

- *Iqta* was a revenue assignment, not ownership of land - this distinction is the exam point.
- The holder was the *muqti* or *iqtdar*; he maintained troops from the revenue and remitted the surplus, called *fawazil*.
- Formalised by *Iltutmish*; made transferable and strictly audited under *Alauddin Khalji*.
- *Firoz Shah* made *iqtas* hereditary - which weakened central control.
- Coins - the silver *tanka* and the copper *jital*, both from *Iltutmish* onwards.

The *iqta* - a revenue assignment, never land ownership



TRAP

An *iqta* is not a *jagir* in the Mughal sense and it is never land ownership. The *muqti* collects revenue, pays troops and sends the surplus up. If an option says the *iqtdar* owned the land, it is wrong.

Provincial kingdoms – the Sultanate breaks into pieces

Every time Delhi weakened, a governor declared independence. By the fifteenth century there were half a dozen rich regional sultanates, each with its own architecture and its own court language. RPSC asks these purely as matching – kingdom to ruler, or kingdom to monument. Four rows will carry you.

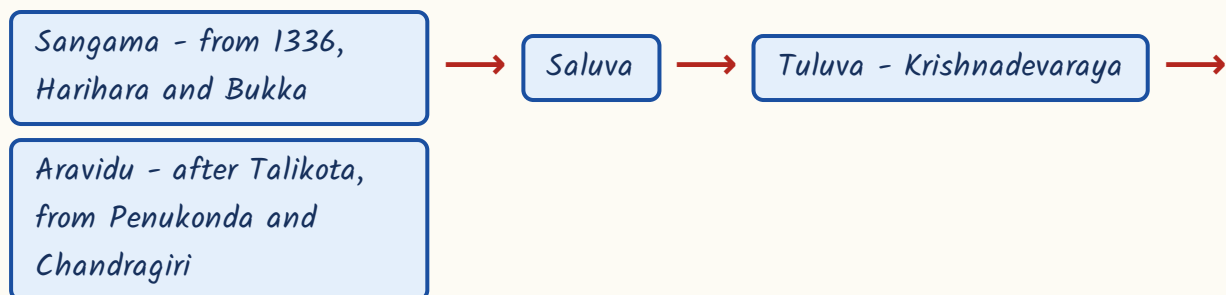
Provincial kingdom to the fact that gets asked

Kingdom	Ruler or dynasty	Remember this
Jaunpur	Sharqi dynasty	Atala Masjid; called the Shiraz of the East
Gujarat	Ahmad Shah	Founded Ahmedabad
Malwa	Sultans of Mandu	Jahaz Mahal at Mandu
Kashmir	Zain-ul-Abidin	Called Budshah, the great king; religious tolerance, Sanskrit patronage
Bengal	Ilyas Shahi and Hussain Shahi	Independent from Delhi through most of this period

Vijayanagara – asked in three consecutive papers, so do it properly

Vijayanagara was founded in 1336 by two brothers, Harihara and Bukka, of the Sangama dynasty, traditionally on the advice of the sage Vidyananya. The capital was Hampi on the Tungabhadra. Four dynasties ruled in succession, and the empire's whole purpose was to hold the south against the Bahmani sultans. RPSC has asked Krishnadevaraya in 2021, 2023 and 2024 – three papers running. That is as clear a signal as this exam ever gives.

The four Vijayanagara dynasties in order



- Krishnadevaraya ruled 1509-1529 and belonged to the Tuluva dynasty.
- Titles - Andhra Bhoja and Abhinava Bhoja.
- Wrote the Amuktamalyada in Telugu and the Jambavati Kalyanam in Sanskrit.
- Built the Vitthalaswamy and Hazara Rama temples at Hampi and founded the town of Nagalapuram.
- The Amuktamalyada is also a treatise on statecraft, not only a poem.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2024 asked who composed the Telugu work Amuktamalyada - answer, Krishnadevaraya himself. RAS Pre 2023 asked which court poet bore the title Andhra Kavita Pitamaha - answer, Allasani Peddana. RAS Pre 2024 also asked in which language Mallanarya, a poet he patronised, wrote - answer, Kannada. Note that last one: Krishnadevaraya's patronage was not Telugu only.

The Ashtadiggajas - the eight Telugu poets of his court

Poet	Work or title
Allasani Peddana	Manucharitramu (Swarochisha Manu Sambhavam); title Andhra Kavita Pitamaha
Nandi Thimmana	Parijatapaharanam
Tenali Ramakrishna	Panduranga Mahatmyamu
Pingali Surana	Raghavapandaveeyamu
Dhurjati	Court poet, devotional verse on Srikalahasti

Poet	Work or title
Madayyagari Mallana	One of the eight
Ayyalaraju Ramabhadru	One of the eight
Ramarajabhushanudu (Bhattumurti)	One of the eight

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2023 set a match-the-following on poet and work: Peddana with Manucharitramu, Nandi Thimmana with Parijatapaharanam, Tenali Ramakrishna with Panduranga Mahatmyamu, Pingali Surana with Raghavapandaveeyamu. Those four pairs are the ones that get used. Memorise the four; recognise the other four names.

- Administration - the Nayankara system of military assignments to nayakas.
- The Ayagar system - twelve hereditary village functionaries running the village.
- Foreign visitors - Nicolo Conti (Italian), Abdur Razzaq (Persian), Domingo Paes, Fernao Nuniz and Duarte Barbosa (Portuguese).
- Battle of Talikota, also called Rakshasa-Tangadi, 1565 - the allied Deccan sultanates defeated Rama Raya and sacked Hampi.
- After Talikota the Aravidu dynasty ruled from Penukonda and later Chandragiri.

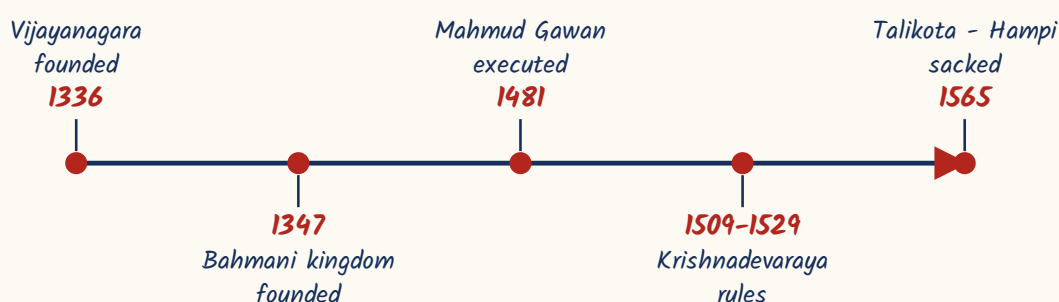
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Current link: Hampi, the Group of Monuments at the Vijayanagara capital, was inscribed by UNESCO in 1986 and spent 1999 to 2006 on the List of World Heritage in Danger before being taken off it. Position as of September 2026. RPSC's current-affairs block regularly pairs a heritage site with its listing status, and Hampi is the one it reaches for in this chapter.

The Bahmani kingdom and its successors

The Bahmani kingdom was the Muslim power of the Deccan and Vijayanagara's permanent rival - the two fought for over two centuries, mostly over the Raichur Doab between the Krishna and the Tungabhadra. It was founded in 1347 by Alauddin Hasan Bahman Shah, better known as Hasan Gangu, after a revolt against Muhammad bin Tughlaq. Its greatest administrator was not a king but a wazir, Mahmud Gawan, and his story is the one that gets asked.

Vijayanagara and the Bahmanis - the five dates



- Founded 1347 by Alauddin Hasan Bahman Shah (Hasan Gangu).
- First capital Gulbarga, shifted to Bidar by Ahmad Shah Wali.
- Mahmud Gawan was wazir under Muhammad Shah III.
- He divided the kingdom into eight tarafs or provinces, tightening central control.
- He built the celebrated madrasa at Bidar and was executed in 1481 on a forged charge - after which the kingdom broke up.

- *Five successor states of the Bahmani kingdom, all founded around 1490-1518.*
- *Adil Shahi at Bijapur; Nizam Shahi at Ahmadnagar; Imad Shahi at Berar.*
- *Qutb Shahi at Golconda; Barid Shahi at Bidar.*
- *It was an alliance of these Deccan sultanates that destroyed Vijayanagara at Talikota in 1565.*

REVISION RECAP

1. Tarain 1191 Prithviraj won, Tarain 1192 Ghoris won, Chandawar 1194 Jaichandra defeated.
2. Five dynasties in order - Slave 1206, Khalji 1290, Tughlaq 1320, Sayyid 1414, Lodi 1451-1526.
3. Aibak - Lakh Baksh, Quwwat-ul-Islam at Delhi, Adhai Din ka Jhonpra at Ajmer, died playing chaugan.
4. Iltutmish - capital to Delhi, iqta, Chalisa, tanka and jital, completed Qutb Minar, Caliph's investiture 1229.
5. Raziya - only woman ruler, raised Yaqut as Amir-i-Akbar, overthrown by the Turkish nobles.
6. Balban - Zill-i-Ilahi, sirdar and paibos, Nauroz, destroyed the Chalisa, created Diwan-i-Arz and the barids.
7. Alauddin's conquests in order - Gujarat 1299, Ranthambore 1301, Chittor 1303, Malwa 1305; Malik Kafur in the Deccan.
8. Market control - Diwan-i-Riyasat over all, Shahna-i-Mandi over grain, barids and munhiyans direct to the Sultan; source Barani.
9. Revenue - kharaj 50 per cent, masahat measurement per biswa, ghari and charai, Diwan-i-Mustakhraj.
10. Alai Darwaza 1311, Siri, Hauz-i-Alai; Alai Minar unfinished; Amir Khusrau Tuti-i-Hind.
11. Muhammad bin Tughlaq - Doab tax, Daulatabad transfer, token currency in copper and brass, Khurasan and Qarachil, Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi.
12. Ibn Battuta made qazi of Delhi, sent to China, wrote the Rihla.
13. Firoz Shah - canals, four Islamic taxes plus haqq-i-sharb one-tenth, jizya on Brahmanas, Ashokan pillars from Topra and Meerut, Futuhat-i-Firozshahi.
14. Timur sacked Delhi 1398; Khizr Khan 1414; Bahlul Lodi 1451 first Afghan; Sikandar Lodi founded Agra 1504; Panipat 21 April 1526.
15. Five diwans - Wizarat finance, Arz military, Insha correspondence, Risalat religious, Qaza justice.

16. *Iqta is a revenue assignment; muqti keeps troops and remits fawazil; hereditary under Firoz Shah.*
17. *Jaunpur Sharqis and the Atala Masjid, Shiraz of the East; Zain-ul-Abidin Budshah of Kashmir; Ahmad Shah founded Ahmedabad.*
18. *Vijayanagara 1336 Harihara and Bukka, Vidyaranya, Hampi on the Tungabhadra; Sangama, Saluva, Tuluva, Aravidu.*
19. *Krishnadevaraya 1509-1529, Tuluva, Andhra Bhoja, Amuktamalyada in Telugu, Jambavati Kalyanam in Sanskrit; Peddana Andhra Kavita Pitamaha.*
20. *Nayankara and Ayagar systems; Talikota 1565 defeated Rama Raya; Bahmani 1347 Hasan Gangu, Gulbarga to Bidar, Mahmud Gawan's eight tarafs, executed 1481.*